Jamestown and Virginia

Other adventures from England tried to colonize America but failed due to a lack of resources. In 1606, the Virginia Company was the first to send out expeditions that actually succeeded. The Company sent two expeditions, one of which was led by Raleigh Gilbert, the son of Sir Humphrey Gilbert. They arrived in modern day Maine in 1606 but abandoned the colony three years later. In 1607, the second voyage arrived in what was known as Jamestown.

Two years later, another wave of settlers arrived in Jamestown but they experienced many hardships. They were forced to deal with disease, starvation and war with the natives. A lot of settlers died as a result. By the following year, those who had survived were ready to abandon the colony and it was only when a new wave of settlers arrived from England did they agree to stay. Sir Thomas Dale arrived the year after and became their Governor. New strict laws were established to keep everyone safe. Anyone who broke those laws faced harsh penalties.

John Rolfe is famous for growing tobacco. After two years of work, he sold tobacco back in England and was able to improve the colony's economy. The Virginia Company gave those who wanted to cross the ocean a choice. Those that could fund their own journey were given 50 acres of land upon arrival. Those who could not fund their journey had to work for the Company as servants.

The Virginia Company was disbanded in 1624 when the English crown took control of the colony. Virginia had a population of around 27,000 at the time. Within 50 years, the population had grown to 78,000. However, there were lots of mosquitos in Jamestown that were causing malaria. Furthermore, the main government building had been burned down several times. In 1699, the local government center was officially transferred to Middle Plantation to resolve these problems. The governor renamed Middle Plantation as Williamsburg, which still exists today.